

GATEWAY: NEWS

License plate cameras are controversial. Here's what one Pierce County city decided

By **Julia Park**

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Lakewood has had 31 Flock Safety automated license plate readers active across the city since early October, which Lakewood police officials say will assist authorities in catching stolen vehicles and solving other crimes. The cameras were strategically placed at city entry and exit points. Lakewood is one of at least three cities or towns in Pierce County to adopt the technology thus far. By Brian Hayes

If you drive through Gig Harbor, your vehicle won't be captured on automated license plate cameras, the Gig Harbor City Council decided on March 24.

Council members rejected a motion that would approve a city contract with private vendor Flock Safety to [install 10 cameras at entry and exit points to the city](#), funded by a grant from the Washington Auto Theft Prevention Authority. The vote followed public comments from close to a dozen residents, most of whom opposed the contract.

Gig Harbor resident Loreto Tessicini told the council he has many questions about Flock and their data sharing and access protocols. He told The News Tribune after the meeting that he previously worked for the federal government.

"What database breach protocols are in place at the cloud level, at the point of contact locally?" Tessicini said during public comment. "I ... urge the City Council to authorize the mayor to not execute a master services agreement (with Flock)."

Christian Cole, an Artondale resident outside of city limits, said he works in data analytics and has friends who work in tech. He's concerned about agencies that could access the data stored by Flock and would be in favor of license plate cameras that automatically delete non-hit license plate data after three minutes.

Lakewood has had 31 Flock Safety automated license plate readers active across the city since early October 2023, which Lakewood police officials say will assist authorities in catching stolen vehicles and solving other crime, Wednesday, Dec. 13, 2023, in Lakewood, Wash. Tony Overman toverman@thenewstribune.com

Two people who work to address retail theft spoke in favor of the cameras. Belfair resident Jeffery Rose said he's a Gig Harbor native and works as a corporate investigator targeting retail theft and fraud offenders. His company started deploying Flock cameras in 2024 and has since partnered with law enforcement agencies to target crime, he told the council.

"I saw immediate impact on suspect identification and case-closure rate," he said. "An organized retail theft repeat offender can be more easily identified as well as located."

He also said the cameras help investigators crack retail-theft fencing operations where the suspects re-sell the stolen merchandise.

“Gig Harbor has been a go-to city for organized retail crime offenders because it has main arterial routes of escape such as Highway 16 and Interstate 5,” he told the council.

In a discussion prior to the vote, council member Reid Ekberg said he doesn’t feel as strongly as others about the risks the cameras pose, but he also feels he doesn’t have as much to lose.

“Someone who wants to track how often I drive my Subaru to Little League practice, go ahead,” he said. “ ... but there were some real concerns from groups tonight that I heard and I ... received numerous written comments that were not in support of this.”

He added that he’d be open to discussing the cameras again at another time, but recognizes that citizens “have said they’re not ready for this at this time.”

Council member Seth Storset said during the council’s discussion that he would support Flock cameras in Gig Harbor in part because he’s concerned that Gig Harbor will become an increased target for crime as surrounding jurisdictions set up their own license plate cameras.

Council member Le Rodenberg also said he believes the cameras would be worth their dollar cost.

“If this could save one senior that took off in his daughter’s car not knowing where he was, if it could save one person, if it could save one child that’s been kidnapped, I think that’s worth \$30,000,” Rodenberg said. “And if it was one of my loved ones, I’d pay it myself.”

Rodenberg’s motion, seconded by Storset, failed in a 2 to 5 vote. Council members Rodenberg and Storset voted in favor and council members Ben Coronado, Reid Ekberg, Roger Henderson, Em Stone and Jeni Woock voted against.

Gig Harbor Police Chief Kelly Busey told The News Tribune after the meeting that the Police Department will forego the \$33,000 grant it received from the Washington State Auto Theft Prevention Authority following the council’s decision. The funds, which had to be spent by June 30, can’t be redirected for another purpose. He doesn’t plan to reapply for the grant next year, he said.

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Julia Park is the Gig Harbor reporter at The News Tribune and writes stories about Gig Harbor, Key Peninsula, Fox Island and other areas across the Tacoma Narrows. She started as a news intern in summer 2024 after graduating from the University of Washington, where she wrote for her student paper, The Daily, freelanced for the South Seattle Emerald and interned at Cascade PBS News (formerly Crosscut).

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